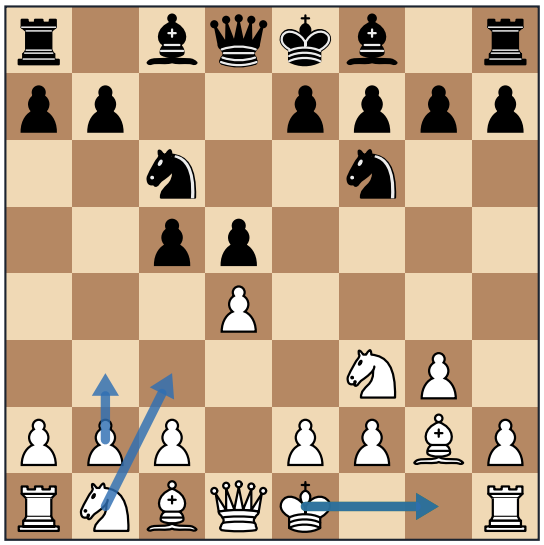
Zukertort Opening

ECO A04-A41 | 47 named lines | Flank openings (English, Reti, Bird, KIA)

In one sentence: Flexible flank openings control the center with pieces and avoid early theoretical battles.

Memory pattern: Fianchetto, control d5 and e5, then pick the center.



Main line: 1.Nf3 d5 2.g3 c5 3.Bg2 Nc6 4.d4 Nf6

Key ideas

1. Control d5 and e5 with pawns on c4 and pieces on f3 and c3.
2. Fianchetto the king's bishop (g3, Bg2) for long-diagonal pressure.
3. Choose a center after seeing Black's setup: d4 or e4.
4. Transpose to Queen's Gambit, Catalan or Sicilian-style structures.
5. English: reversed Sicilian ideas with extra tempo.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.39** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best: O-O.

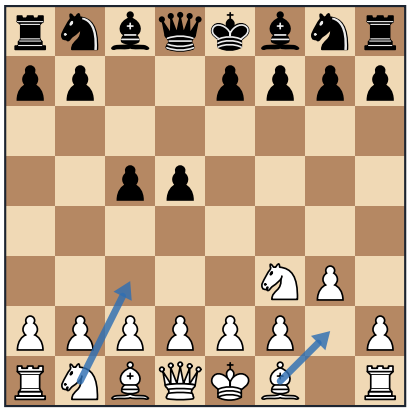
The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Control d5/e5 with pieces and keep the centre flexible (Reversed Sicilian, Reti, King's Indian Attack). Transpositions are common.
2. Where does my king go?	Castle short; g3/Bg2 is a safe shelter.
3. Best minor pieces?	Bg2 and Bb2 on the long diagonals, knights c3/f3, breaks with d4/e4.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Choose a centre after seeing Black's setup; expand with b4 or d4; attack with e4/Ne5.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants a favourable centre; Black wants to claim the centre with ...e5/...d5 or symmetrical counterplay.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.Nf3 d5 2.g3 c5 3.Bg2 Nc6 4.d4 Nf6

Move	Why it is played
1. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
1... d5	Hit c4. Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. g3	Fianchetto. Gains space on the wing.
2... c5	Symmetry and central pressure.
3. Bg2	Long diagonal. Fianchetto: the bishop takes the long diagonal.
3... Nc6	Develops the knight to c6.
4. d4	Central break. Occupies the center with a pawn.
4... Nf6	Develops the knight to f6.



After 1.Nf3 d5 2.g3 c5

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

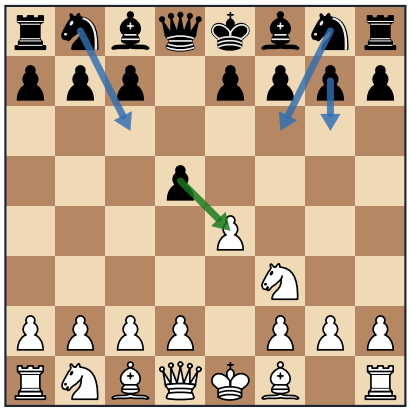


Position after the line

Reversed Grünfeld A08 | 4 lines

`1.Nf3 d5 2.g3 c5 3.Bg2 Nc6 4.d4`

Stockfish: **+0.40** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Nf6.
What to look for: e5 (take the center); Nf6 (develop); d5 (hit c4)

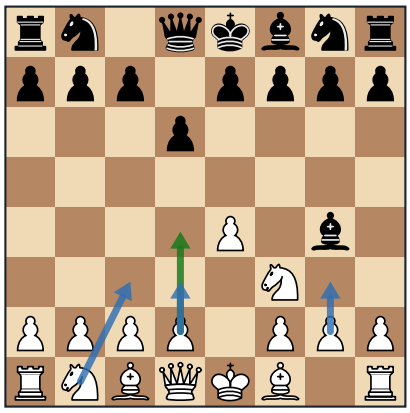


Position after the line

Tennison Gambit A06 | 2 lines

`1.e4 d5 2.Nf3`

Stockfish: **-1.01** (clearly better for Black, depth 18). Best next move: dxe4.
What to look for: e5 (take the center); Nf6 (develop); d5 (hit c4)
Sub-variations: Brigg's Trap

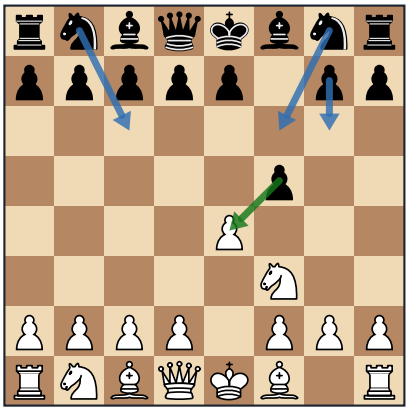


Position after the line

Wade Defense A04 | 2 lines

`1.Nf3 d6 2.e4 Bg4`

Stockfish: **+0.92** (clearly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: d4.
What to look for: c4 (control d5); Nf3 (develop); g3 (fianchetto)
Sub-variations: Chigorin Plan

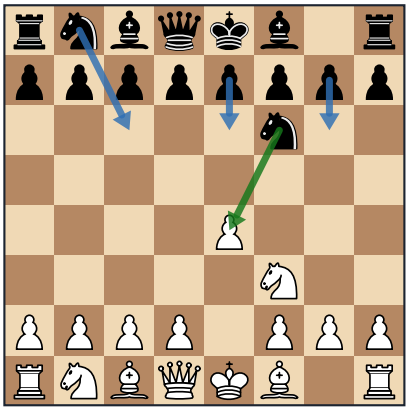


Position after the line

Lisitsyn Gambit A04 | 1 lines

`1.Nf3 f5 2.e4`

Stockfish: **+0.00** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: fxe4.
What to look for: e5 (take the center); Nf6 (develop); d5 (hit c4)

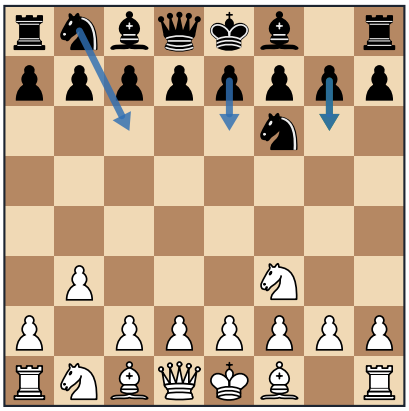


Position after the line

Lemberger Gambit A05 | 1 lines

`1.Nf3 Nf6 2.e4`

Stockfish: **-0.78** (clearly better for Black, depth 16). Best next move: Nxe4.
What to look for: e5 (take the center); Nf6 (develop); d5 (hit c4)



Position after the line

Nimzo-Larsen Variation A05 | 1 lines

`1.Nf3 Nf6 2.b3`

Stockfish: **-0.02** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: g6.
What to look for: e5 (take the center); Nf6 (develop); d5 (hit c4)

Detailed repertoire notes

Reti / King's Indian Attack (A04-A09, White)

```
1.Nf3 d5 2.g3 Nf6 3.Bg2 e6 4.O-O Be7 5.d3 O-O 6.Nbd2 c5 7.e4 Nc6 8.Re1 b5 9.e5 Nd7
```

Idea: Delay pawn commitments, fianchetto, and choose the center based on Black's setup.

Structure: KIA structure: e4-d3 with Bg2; the d3-e4 chain supports a kingside attack, or e5 gains space.

Pieces: Bg2 (long diagonal), knights d2-f1 or d2-e4, queen on e2, rooks e1/d1.

Plan: Complete the setup, play e4, and launch a kingside attack (Ne5, f4, h4). If Black fianchettoes, switch to c4 ideas.

King: Castle early, then attack the kingside with e4/e5. **Opponent:** ...c5 and ...Nc6 hitting d4/e4, or a quick ...e5.

Watch out: Do not become passive; transpose to Catalan or English when needed.

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Flank openings are about flexibility, not speed. Make sure you know the main transpositions and what structures you want, then choose moves accordingly.

Why play it

Flexible flank openings control the center with pieces and avoid early theoretical battles.

Typical mistakes

- Being too passive and letting Black take the center for free.
- Playing d3 and e4 without a plan for the queenside pawns.
- Neglecting development while chasing a fianchetto.

Typical tactics and traps

- Early Qb3 or Qa4 pins that win the c4 or d5 pawn if Black is careless.
- Tactics on the long diagonal against b7/g7.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Balanced, flexible endgames with minor advantages for the better-placed bishops.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Zukertort Opening (all lines)** — A04
  `1.Nf3`
  - **Arctic Defense** — A04
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...f6`
    - **Drunken Knight Variation** — A04
      `1.Nf3 f6 -> 2.e4 Nh6 3.d4 Nf7`
  - **Basman Defense** — A04
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...h6`
  - **Black Mustang Defense** — A04
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...Nc6`
  - **Dutch Variation** — A04
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...f5`
  - **Herrstrom Gambit** — A04
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...g5`
  - **Kingside Fianchetto** — A04
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...g6`
  - **Pirc Invitation** — A04
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...d6`
  - **Polish Defense** — A04
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...b5`
  - **Queen's Gambit Invitation** — A04
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...e6`
  - **Queenside Fianchetto Variation** — A04
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...b6`
  - **Ross Gambit** — A04
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...e5`
  - **Sicilian Invitation** — A04
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...c5`
  - **Slav Invitation** — A04
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...c6`
  - **St. George Defense** — A04
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...a6`
  - **Ware Defense** — A04
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...a5`
  - **Ampel Variation** — A06
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...d5 2.Rg1`
  - **Lemberger Gambit** — A05
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...Nf6 2.e4`
  - **Lisitsyn Gambit** — A04
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...f5 2.e4`
  - **Nimzo-Larsen Variation** — A05
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...Nf6 2.b3`
  - **Old Indian Attack** — A06
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...d5 2.d3`
  - **Quiet System** — A05
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...Nf6 2.e3`
  - **Reversed Mexican Defense** — A06
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...d5 2.Nc3`
  - **Santasiere's Folly** — A06
    `1.b4 d5 2.Nf3`
  - **Tennison Gambit** — A06
    `1.e4 d5 2.Nf3`
    - **Brigg's Trap** — A06
      `1.e4 d5 2.Nf3 -> 2...dxe4 3.Ng5 Nf6 4.Nc3 Bf5 5.Qe2 Qd4`
  - **The Potato** — A06
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...d5 2.a4`
  - **Drunken Cavalry Variation** — A04
    `1.Nf3 -> 1...Na6 2.e4 Nh6`

- **Vos Gambit** A04
  1.Nf3 -> 1...d6 2.d4 e5
- **Wade Defense** A04
  1.Nf3 -> 1...d6 2.e4 Bg4
  - **Chigorin Plan** A41
    1.d4 d6 2.Nf3 Bg4 3.c4 Nd7 4.Qb3 Rb8
- **Lisitsyn Gambit Deferred** A04
  1.Nf3 -> 1...f5 2.d3 Nf6 3.e4
- **Myers Polish Attack** A05
  1.Nf3 -> 1...Nf6 2.a4 g6 3.b4
- **Speelsmet Gambit** A04
  1.Nf3 -> 1...c5 2.d4 cxd4 3.e3
- **The Walrus** A04
  1.Nf3 -> 1...e5 2.Nxe5 Nc6 3.Nxc6 dxc6
- **Pachman Gambit** A06
  1.Nf3 -> 1...d5 2.e3 c5 3.c4 dxc4 4.b3
- **Regina-Nu Gambit** A06
  1.Nf3 -> 1...d5 2.b3 c5 3.c4 dxc4 4.Nc3
- **Reversed Grünfeld** A08
  1.Nf3 -> 1...d5 2.g3 c5 3.Bg2 Nc6 4.d4
- **Shabalov Gambit** A04
  1.Nf3 -> 1...e6 2.c4 a6 3.Nc3 c5 4.g3 b5
- **Double Fianchetto Attack** A05
  1.Nf3 -> 1...Nf6 2.g3 g6 3.b3 Bg7 4.Bb2 O-O 5.Bg2 d6 6.O-O

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.Nf3 d5 2.g3 c5 3.Bg2 Nc6 4.d4 Nf6
```

Plan chain

White	c4 -> Nf3 -> g3 -> Bg2 -> O-O
Black	e5 -> Nf6 -> d5 -> c5 -> g6

Three rules to remember

1. Fianchetto, control d5 and e5, then pick the center.

2. Choose a centre after seeing Black's setup; expand with b4 or d4; attack with e4/Ne5.

3. White wants a favourable centre; Black wants to claim the centre with ...e5/...d5 or symmetrical counterplay.

Pawn structure in one line

Control d5/e5 with pieces and keep the centre flexible (Reversed Sicilian, Reti, King's Indian Attack). Transpositions are common.